

History painting

From the High Renaissance until the 19th century, history painting was considered the most important and prestigious artistic genre in Western art. In this context, the word 'history' relates to the Italian word *istoria*, meaning a narrative or story – so history paintings can represent historical events, biblical or mythological stories, allegories or other forms of secular literature. Traditionally, history paintings had to incorporate several figures in some sort of emotionally charged activity. In his 1435 treatise *On Painting*, Italian art expert Alberti described *istoria* as the most difficult type of painting, and emphasized the importance of portraying interaction with gesture and expression.

History painting was originally created to decorate public areas, such as in churches, town halls and palaces. Usually painted on a grand scale, history paintings conventionally created serious, morally uplifting narratives to inspire and educate contemporary viewers. In the late 19th century, as artists began to rebel against the art establishment, history painting became less significant.



Titian, *Diana and Actaeon*, 1556–9